

HEALTHY COOKING DEMONSTRATION

MEET YOUR INSTRUCTORS



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Nutrition Basics

A simple guide to the core components of a healthy diet for senior citizens.

THE THREE MAIN FUEL SOURCES



Protein: The Body's Building Blocks

Essential for maintaining muscles, skin, and organs; found in meat, eggs, and beans.



Carbohydrates: Your Daily Gasoline

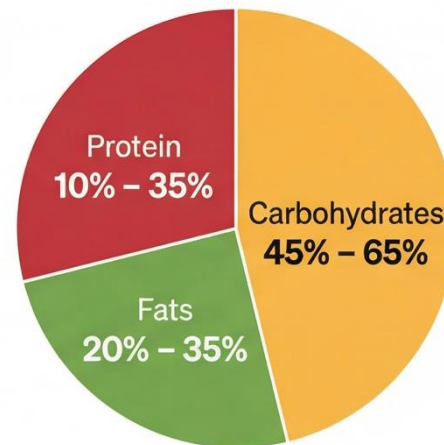
The main fuel source; choose complex carbs like whole grains for sustained energy.



Fats: Vital for Brain Health

Focus on "good" unsaturated fats like olive oil and nuts for long-lasting energy.

Recommended Daily Calorie Distribution



ESSENTIAL DAILY SUPPORT



Hydration is Essential

Water makes up 60% of your weight; aim for 8-10 cups daily.



Vitamins & Minerals for Vitality

These organic elements support specific needs like bone strength and heart health.



Calorie Quality Matters

Focus on nutrient-rich foods, as quality affects your body more than quantity.

Healthy Eating after Fifty

Adjusting your diet for muscle, bone health, and cognitive function as you age.

Essential Nutrients for Vitality



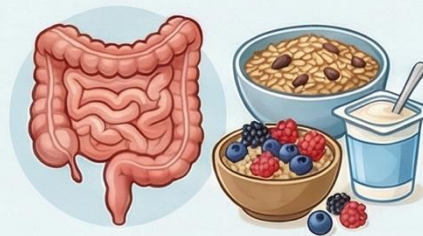
Boost Protein to .5g per Pound

Consuming enough protein throughout the day helps prevent age-related muscle loss.



Aim for 1,200 mg of Calcium Daily

Increased calcium and 800-1,000 IU of Vitamin D are essential for maintaining bone density.



Prioritize Fiber and Probiotics

Eat 25-30g of fiber and probiotic foods like yogurt to support a slowing digestive system.

Smart Daily Habits



Drink Water Intentionally

Since the sense of thirst decreases with age, set reminders to stay well-hydrated.



Limit Sodium to 1,500–2,300 mg

Reduce salt intake to manage blood pressure, using herbs and spices for flavor instead.



Choose Anti-Inflammatory Foods

Focus on fatty fish, colorful berries, and leafy greens to support brain and heart health.

The Benefits to Eating Healthy

Physical Vitality



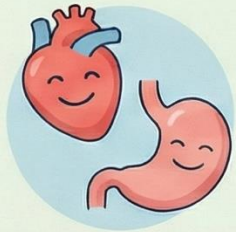
Increased Daily Energy

Gain the stamina needed for gardening, shopping, and playing with grandchildren.



Stronger Bones and Muscles

Improve balance and ease of movement while significantly reducing the risk of falls.



Better Digestion and Heart Health

Reduce post-meal discomfort and improve the ability to walk without getting winded.

Sharp Mind & Well-being



Sharper Memory and Focus

Reduce "brain fog" and improve the recall of names, appointments, and recent events.



Improved Sleep and Mood

Enjoy more restful nights and more stable, positive emotions throughout the day.



Independence and Confidence

Maintain the mental clarity and physical strength to live independently and stay social.

The New Upside-Down Food Pyramid (2025-2030)

Priority: Protein, Dairy, and Healthy Fats

Prioritize high-quality animal and plant proteins, full-fat dairy, eggs, seafood, nuts, and seeds.



Secondary: Fruits and Vegetables

Target three servings of vegetables and two servings of fruit daily.



Base: Whole Grains

Aim for 2–4 daily servings of whole grains while strictly avoiding refined carbohydrates.

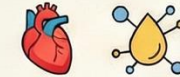


Expert Concerns & Considerations



The Fiber Gap

Experts warn that 95% of Americans already lack sufficient fiber, which this pyramid deprioritizes.



Saturated Fat Risk

The pyramid's emphasis on red meat and cheese may exceed the recommended 10% calorie limit.

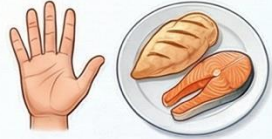


Not One-Size-Fits-All

Dietitians recommend balancing animal proteins with plant-based sources like legumes for optimal gut health.

Portion Measurement

Handy Visual Cues



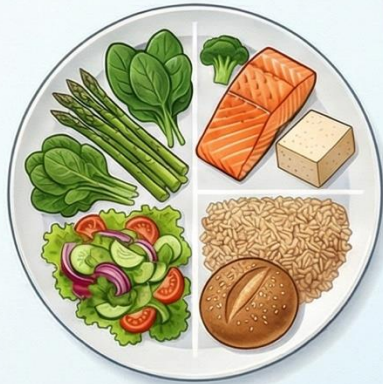
The Hand Method

Use your palm for protein and your fist for vegetables or carbohydrates



Small Measures

Use your thumb for fats and a cupped hand for snacks or nuts



The Plate Rule

Fill half your plate with vegetables and a quarter each with protein and grains

Household Comparisons

Meat & Proteins

A deck of cards represents a standard 3 oz serving of meat



Grains & Fruits

Use a tennis ball to visualize a 1/2 cup serving of rice or pasta



Large Servings

A baseball represents a full 1 cup serving of vegetables or cereal



Quick Reference for Smaller Additions



Golf Ball:
2 tablespoons
(Peanut butter/Dressing)



Kitchen Scale:
Best for precise meat
and cheese weights



Measuring Cups:
Recommended for
oils and grains

Meal Basics

THE FOUNDATION: PROTEINS & GRAINS

Proteins (Choose 1-2)



Chicken, Salmon, Eggs



Beans, Tofu



Greek Yogurt,
Cottage Cheese



Batch Cook for Ease

Include animal-based options like chicken, salmon, or eggs; plant-based choices like beans or tofu; or dairy such as Greek yogurt and cottage cheese.

Whole Grains & Starches (Choose 1)



Oats

Farro



Whole Wheat Pasta



Sweet Potatoes



Oats, Farro, Whole
Wheat Pasta,

Instant brown rice and pre-cooked quinoa are excellent quick alternatives.

THE COLORFUL PLATE: VEGETABLES & FRUITS

Aim for a Variety of Colors



Leafy Greens, Colorful Vegetables, Starchy Options

Fruit for Fiber and Flavor



Keep the skin on apples and pears for maximum nutrients, and use citrus zest or juice to add bright flavor to savory meals.

Frozen is Functional



Buy frozen berries for year-round availability and convenience; they are perfect for adding to oatmeal or yogurt.

ENHANCING THE MEAL: FATS & FLAVOR

Healthy Fats (Choose 1)



Olive Oil, Avocado,
Nuts, Seeds

Use olive oil, avocado, nuts, or seeds to add satiety; remember that a little goes a long way for cooking or toppings.

Flavor Makers



Fresh Herbs (Basil, Parsley), Aromatics
(Garlic, Onion), Spices (Turmeric, Cumin),
Acids (Lemon Juice, Balsamic Vinegar)

Transform simple ingredients into exciting meals using fresh herbs, aromatics, spices, or acids.

SIMPLE MEAL COMBINATIONS



Balanced Breakfasts

Try Greek yogurt with berries and nuts, or whole grain toast topped with nut butter and sliced strawberries.



Savory Pairings

Combine pork with apples, chicken with peaches, or fish with citrus to integrate fruit into main courses.



Nutritious Snacks & Desserts

Enjoy an apple with almond butter for a snack, or try a baked apple with cinnamon as a healthy dessert alternative.

Sample Recipes

Mediterranean Bowl Composition



Mediterranean Finishing Touches

Olive oil
ony-my
oregano.



Add olive oil and
olives for healthy
fats, seasoned with
lemon and oregano.

The Five-Element Formula

Protein + Vegetables + Grain/Starch +
Healthy Fat + Flavor = Complete Meal.



Protein



Vegetables



Grain/Starch



Healthy Fat



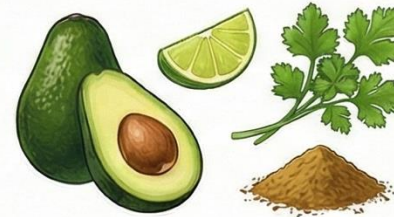
Flavor

Mexican-Style Plate

Mexican Plate Foundation



Mexican Flavor Profile



Top with avocado for healthy
fats and season with cilantro,
lime, and cumin.

Asian-Inspired Stir-Fry

Stir-Fry Core Ingredients



Stir-Fry Flavoring



Use shrimp as the protein,
paired with a mix of
broccoli and bell
peppers over brown rice.



Quick Options

Yogurt Parfait

A simple combination
of Greek yogurt, fresh
fruit, and crunchy
granola.



The Stovetop Grill Chicken

Preparation & Ingredients



The Main Protein
Use 2 chicken breasts, pounded to an even thickness of about 1/2 inch to ensure uniform cooking.



Essential Cooking Oil
Use 1 tablespoon of high-smoke point oil, such as avocado or vegetable oil, to handle the high-heat sear.



The "Grilled" Seasoning Blend
Mix 1 tsp salt, 1/2 tsp black pepper, 1 tsp garlic powder, and 1 tsp smoked paprika for that authentic smoky flavor.



The Flavorful Finish
Have 1 tablespoon of butter and a fresh lemon wedge ready to add brightness and moisture at the end.

The 6-Step Cooking Process



1 Prep and Season
Pat the chicken completely dry with paper towels to prevent steaming, then rub both sides generously with the seasoning mix.



2 Heat the Pan
Set a skillet over medium-high heat with oil until it shimmers and shows fine wisps of smoke.



3 The Initial Sear
Place chicken in the pan and leave it undisturbed for 5-6 minutes to develop a deep golden-brown crust.



4 The Flip
Turn the chicken over and immediately lower the stove temperature to medium heat.



5 The Butter Baste
Add butter to the pan; once foaming, tilt the pan and spoon the hot butter over the chicken for the final 3-4 minutes.



6 Rest for Juiciness
Remove chicken once it reaches an internal temperature of 165°F (74°C) and let it rest for 5 minutes before slicing.

Pro-Tips for Success



Avoid Overcrowding
If cooking more than two breasts, work in batches to keep the pan temperature high enough for browning.



Use "The Press"
For an extra-crispy crust, use a heavy spatula to press the chicken down firmly during the first minute of searing.



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Deglaze for Sauce
After removing the meat, add a splash of chicken broth to the hot pan to scrape up the flavorful brown bits for a quick sauce.

Classic Dijon Vinaigrette: A Simple & Healthy Homemade Dressing

A guide for seniors to create a heart-healthy, emulsified salad dressing at home using simple ingredients and two easy methods.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED



1/2 Cup Extra Virgin Olive Oil
Use a high-quality oil for the best heart-healthy fats since it is served raw.



1/4 Cup Vinegar
White wine, Red wine, or Champagne vinegar provide the best balanced tang.



1 tbsp Dijon Mustard
This acts as a natural emulsifier to keep the dressing creamy; use smooth or whole grain.



Aromatics: Shallot & Garlic
1 small finely minced shallot (1 tbsp)
1 clove of grated or minced garlic for savory depth.



1 tsp Honey or Maple Syrup
An optional addition to help balance the acidity of the vinegar.



Seasoning
Add salt and pepper to your personal taste preference.

METHOD 1 - THE MASON JAR (EASIEST)



Combine All Ingredients

Place the oil, vinegar, mustard, aromatics, and sweetener into a small glass jar.



SHAKE

Shake Vigorously

Tighten the lid and shake for 30 seconds until the mixture is opaque and creamy.

✓ Easiest

METHOD 2 - THE WHISK (SMOOTHEST)



Whisk the Base

In a bowl, combine the mustard, vinegar, shallots, garlic, and honey first.



The Slow Drizzle

While whisking constantly, slowly pour in the olive oil in a thin, steady stream until thick.

✓ Smoothest

PRO-TIPS FOR SUCCESS



Mellow the "Zip"

If the dressing is too sharp, whisk in 1 tablespoon of warm water to soften the vinegar flavor.



Storage & Temperature

Olive oil solidifies in the fridge; let the jar sit out for 15 minutes or run under warm water before serving.



Easy Flavor Variations

Try "Lemon-Dijon" by replacing half the vinegar with lemon juice, or "Herb-Forward" by adding dried oregano or fresh tarragon.

The “Universal” Veggie Mix

Easy Air-Fryer Healthy Cooking



Step 1: Prep & Season



Cut for Uniformity

Chop broccoli, peppers, zucchini, and red onion into uniform 1-inch, bite-sized pieces to ensure they all cook at the same rate.

The Flavor Coating

Toss veggies in a bowl with 1-2 tbsp olive oil, 1 tsp garlic powder, 1 tsp Italian seasoning, salt, and pepper until every piece is glossy.



Don't Skip the Oil

Oil is essential because it conducts the air fryer's heat to create those delicious, crispy, charred edges.



Step 2: The Air Fryer Method



Preheat to 390°F (200°C)

Always preheat your air fryer for 3 minutes before adding the vegetables to ensure the cooking cycle starts at the right temperature.

Half-Full is the Rule

Place veggies in the basket; it is okay if they overlap slightly, but never fill the basket more than halfway to allow air to circulate.



Cook and Shake

Set the timer for 10-15 minutes, but stop to shake the basket vigorously at the 6 or 7-minute mark for even browning.



Look for the Char

The mix is finished when the edges are dark brown/charred and the centers of the vegetables are tender.



Customization & Timing Guide



The Staggered Method

If mixing hard roots (carrots) with soft veggies (zucchini), cook the hard ones for 8 minutes first before adding the soft ones.

Veggie Cooking Time Cheat Sheet (390°F)

Veggie Type	Examples	Cooking Time
Thin/Small	Asparagus, Green Beans, Snap Peas	6-8 mins
Soft/Tender	Zucchini, Peppers, Mushrooms, Broccoli	10-12 mins
Hard/Root	Carrots, Potatoes, Brussels Sprouts	15-20 mins

Three Ways to Level Up



The Umami Bomb

For a savory finish, toss the vegetables in a splash of balsamic glaze or soy sauce immediately after cooking.



The Crunch

Add a salty kick by sprinkling 2 tbsp of grated Parmesan cheese over the veggies for the final 2 minutes of air frying.



The Zest

Squeeze fresh lemon juice over the dish right before serving to cut through the roasted richness and brighten the flavor.